

Amy C. Edmondson

Psychological Safety & the Fearless Organization

b. 1959 · Novartis Professor of Leadership & Management · Harvard Business School



"Psychological safety is not about being nice."

"The absence of psychological safety leaves people unwilling to offer ideas."

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Why do some smart teams never share their best ideas? Edmondson's answer — psychological safety — is the single strongest predictor of team creativity and learning. If you want candour, dissent and idea-sharing, this is the variable you manage first.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

American scholar of leadership and organisational behaviour at Harvard Business School. Her doctoral work on hospital teams produced the modern concept of psychological safety, later extended to teaming, learning and innovation across industries.

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Psychological Safety	Shared belief the team is safe for interpersonal risk
The Fearless Organization	Framework for building safety at scale
Teaming	Coordinating and learning on the fly across boundaries
Intelligent failure	Distinguishing praiseworthy from blameworthy failure
The 2x2 of accountability × safety	High safety + high standards = the learning zone

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Frame work as a learning problem, not an execution problem
- Model fallibility as a leader to invite candour
- Reward the messenger for surfacing bad news early
- Separate blameworthy from intelligent, learning-rich failure
- Pair high psychological safety with high performance standards

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Safety can be misread as lowered standards if unpaired with accountability
- Hard to build in steep hierarchies or fear-based cultures
- Measurement relies on self-report surveys
- Context-dependent — what feels safe varies by group
- Leaders can undermine it faster than they build it

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- Coined and validated 'psychological safety', now mainstream
- Central to Google's Project Aristotle findings on effective teams
- Repeatedly ranked among the world's most influential thinkers
- Reframed failure as a source of organisational learning
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Unit 2 team creativity

SELECTED WORKS

THE FEARLESS ORGANIZATION <i>Creating Psychological Safety</i> EDMONDSON · 2019	TEAMING <i>How Organizations Learn and Compete</i> EDMONDSON · 2012	RIGHT KIND OF WRONG <i>The Science of Failing Well</i> EDMONDSON · 2023	BUILDING THE FUTURE <i>with Susan Salter Reynolds</i> EDMONDSON · 2016
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REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Edmondson, A.C. (2019) *The Fearless Organization*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

Edmondson, A.C. (1999) 'Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams', *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 44(2), pp. 350–383.